

HEADS
OVER
Tails

A NOVEL BY
Cherry

Jazzi



"Baby." Seven repeated, this time snapping Jazzi out of her daze. "Are you okay?"

"Mmm hmm." She mumbled focusing on his face as she tried her best to remember what they were talking about.

"The waitress wants to know what you want to drink."

"Oh." Jazzi just noticed the waitress standing at their table. "I'll have a water and a strawberry margarita on the rocks, no sugar no salt. Thank you."

Seven didn't need to know that although it was only three o'clock, this would be her fourth drink, especially since their circumstances had changed so much within the last ten minutes. Right before Seven arrived for their lunch, Ericka Wright, a master weaveologist, if that was even a word, stopped by the bar Jazzi sat at. Ericka told her that she was looking for a new shop in town, which was wonderful news to her. As a matter of fact the only thing that made Jazzi happier was seeing her man pull into the parking lot. Jazzi was preparing to introduce Ericka to the love of her life, the man she was ready to give her all to. This was something she

hadn't done in so many years that she actually couldn't remember the last time it happened, or with whom, for that matter. But as soon as Seven stepped out of the car, Jazzi saw a horrified look on Ericka's face. The mere sight of Seven had sent sheer fright and panic through Ericka who a few seconds later, jumped up and ran out the back door of the restaurant, setting off the alarms.

"Jazzi."

"Hmm."

"Baby what's wrong?" Seven asked frowning. "I've been talking but you haven't heard one word I've said."

Jazzi could tell that he was confused, hell, she was too. But for now she needed him to either shut up or keep rambling until she could come up with a game plan.

"I'm sorry honey. I'm listening I've just got a lot on my mind, go ahead."

Jazzi watched Seven's lips move but her mind tuned out everything he said. Instead she wondered what could this amazingly handsome man with such gorgeous mocha skin, a perfectly trimmed goatee, suckable lips, neatly-trimmed thick eyebrows, low-cut Caesar with waves you ached to touch, dark brown eyes and a body built for pleasure could have possibly done to Ericka to make her almost jump out of her skin and sprint to the back exit, to avoid him seeing her? Ericka was clearly terrified and Jazzi needed to know why. She also needed to know what Ericka knew. Seven's lips were still moving, Jazzi smiled slightly and shook her head in agreement, to what, she had no idea.

The waitress came back with their drinks. Jazzi took the straw from the woman's hand before it could even hit

the table. There was no way she was leaving this drink behind and she had no intentions of staying very long. Unfortunately the latest events had altered their Wednesday lunch date. Seven just didn't know it yet. She couldn't sit there and pretend to listen to foolishness when there were answers she needed to get. She sucked down her drink in one long gulp never taking her eyes off of Seven. Once again she hadn't asked enough questions, she silently admonished herself. She'd taken a man at face value allowing that to be enough. She wasn't supposed to *still* be making these mistakes, she was seasoned now. More mature, or so she thought. But here she was, upset, because for the first time in more months than she could now count, she'd been shoved off cloud nine. And the worst part of it all was that she'd fallen head over heels for a man that she didn't even know. The only things she knew was that he owned his own business, his address, what he drove, that he didn't have kids (so he said) and that he'd been married once before. That was it. Now that she thought about it, she'd never met any friends or family or even co-workers. Hell the only person she knew was him. They'd entered each other's world and made a haven for just the two of them. Jazzi realized her only other world besides Seven, was work and Mina. And for some stupid reason, until Ericka popped in today, she was all right with it, but clearly not anymore.

Jazzi picked up her phone as Seven continued to talk. She wanted to believe he was innocent. Lord knows she was praying he was, but women didn't freak out and run away from innocent men. She needed to start right now, so whatever he was talking about couldn't have been more important than the information she needed to find out about his ass. She turned the ringer off and set the alarm that matched her ringtone for the next minute. No way did

she need the phone to ring while she was pretending to be on the phone setting up her escape because of a fictitious emergency. No, her game was way tighter than that. Her motto was: “When you *stay* ready there’s no *getting* ready,” which went well with her obsession of pre-planning everything. A minute later the alarm, which sounded like her regular ringtone rang.

“Now they know I’m at lunch. I’m sorry honey I have to get this.” She smiled apologetically at Seven. “This is Jasmine. Hey. What? When? Are you sure?” Jazzi checked her watch for the time. “That’s in twenty-five minutes. Okay...okay. Text me the conference call information and if I’m not back in the office before it starts I’ll just dial in from the car. Thanks. Okay...bye.” Jazzi then hung up from her made-up conversation. “Baby. I have got to go. My department heads have called an impromptu meeting with the entire staff, so this must be big.” Jazzi said as she stood up.

She tried to give Seven a quick peck on the cheek before running out of the door but he was too much of a gentlemen for that. At least with *her*. He stood up and gave her a long slow passionate kiss on the lips. Any other day, any other time, a kiss like that would have sat Jazzi back in her seat but not today.

“Baby I love you and I’ll call or text as soon as I can, after the meeting. You go ahead and order, and you can watch me walk to the car how about that?”

“Yeah, ‘cause you know I’d rather walk you right?”

“I know, that’s why I love you. You go ahead and order...enjoy lunch for me okay?”

“I’ll call Maggiano’s and have them deliver your favorite dish so it should get to the office shortly after you.” Seven said, thoughtfully.

“I love you so much Seven.” Jazzi said, and she really did love him. Jazzi prayed that whatever Ericka was running from in him, wasn’t enough to make her also flee. She kissed Seven once more, then headed for the door. Mina had called while she was talking to Erika, but she was going to have to wait for a call back. Talk about bigger fish to fry, shoot I’m frying sharks over here, Jazzi thought. By the time she sat in the driver’s seat of her BMW the only person she was thinking about calling was Michael Walters. Jazzi held down the record button on her phone. “Seven is going to have Maggiano’s deliver my lunch, when it comes please put it in the fridge. He shouldn’t call but in case he does I’m in a meeting, so just take a message. Confirm that you’ve received this message when you get it please.” She sent the message to her assistant. Thirty seconds later. *Got it boss*, appeared on her screen.

Jazzi plugged her phone into the car jack then said, “Call Michael Walters.” A moment later the phone dialed the number.

“Hello, Walter’s Investigation.”

“Hi Kimberley it’s Jasmine. Is Michael there?”

“No, he’s not in at the moment. But if you hold on a second I’ll forward you to his cell.”

“Okay, thanks.” Jazzi said, drumming her fingers on the steering wheel.

“Thank you ma’am.”

This girl can't be from Charlotte, that thick country accent has Alabama or Mississippi all over it, Jazzi thought as she waited for the transfer. She couldn't believe she was having to pull out her big guns. And never in a million years did she think Seven would be the reason. But the way Ericka ran out of the restaurant was something she'd never seen before. Jazzi realized she was probably doing this because *she* needed validation. She needed to know that Seven wasn't a bad guy. At least not in a way that she couldn't justify staying with him. She wanted to believe that for once in her life it was her turn. Her turn for happiness, her turn for the too good to be true, to *actually* be true.

Most women she knew her age had children, were married or had at least been married once. She wanted that too. She hoped to at least experience one of the two. She yearned to have a relationship that made it to the next level and continued to prevail. She knew that marriage didn't equate to everyday sunshine. But she was ready to take the thunderstorms and bad days too, as long as they came out on the other end together. She knew she was a good woman and wife material. She was just waiting for a real man, a good man to figure it out and change her status. Jazzi wanted that man to be Seven. But depending on the news Walter reported back, Seven could possibly become a distant memory. The agony of not knowing was starting to eat her alive. She had plans on more mornings of waking up beside him making breakfast and sharing smiles and laughter while they sipped their coffee. Now the thought of leaving him tormented her.

"Jasmine Franklin. How are you dear? And to what do I owe this lovely surprise?"

“Hey Walter. You know I love and hate calling you at the same time. But I have a situation. I need everything you can get me on someone I’ve been dating.”

“That’s what I do best. How long have you been dating?”

“Almost a year.”

“Holy cow! You waited a year to call me?”

“I wanted to hope and have faith.” She didn’t want to say it because she knew what was coming next.

“How many times do I have to tell you? Women like you and Mina need details and facts when it comes to investing your finances, lifestyles and lives with men.” Walter sighed deeply before continuing. “So tell me what happened? Things were great for a year and now you’re on the phone with me.”

“I was meeting him for lunch.”

“What’s his name?”

“Seven McKenzie.”

Walter paused. “No. The name doesn’t ring any bells.”

“Well I saw an old friend, Ericka, at the restaurant and started talking to her. When Seven pulled up and got out of the car Ericka looked like she saw a ghost and hauled ass out the back door setting off the alarm. Before she jetted she said ‘Seven is your man? *No Jazzi.*’ Then she took off and alarms started going off, *literally.*”

“Wow.”

Who you telling, Jazzi thought.

“What’s Ericka’s last name?”

“Wright with a W.” Jazzi heard Walter writing notes down.

“Well, we’ll definitely start there. First thing’s first; we need to find out everything we know about Seven McKenzie and most importantly how he knows Ms. Ericka Wright. Do you know his date of birth, employer, address and year, make, and model of his car?”

“I sure do.”

“Great. Text me all that information with a picture too if you have one. And I’ll get started right away, which honestly will be in about two days. You know you get first priority but I’m wrapping up something big and will be out of the country for another two days. But when I get back your case will be next.” Walter paused for a moment. “How important is this to you? Do you want the bits and pieces as I get them? Or do you want me to hold the information and compile a full report?”

Jazzi didn’t have to ponder that one. Normally she’d want a full report. But not this time. If she had to get it bit by bit and piece by piece until she was able to put the puzzle together then so be it.

“Give it to me when and how you get it. And if I don’t answer send a text, I’m all right with that.”

“Okay. I’ll let you know when my plane lands so you’ll know the moment I start working.”

“Thank you Walter.”

“You got it Ms. Franklin.”

Jazzie hung up the phone feeling both confident and reluctant. She would get answers but she had to wait for them. *What am I going to do for two days? Make it three to four because he has to get the information.* Anxiety was putting her on edge.

She had no idea how she was going to stay calm and be affectionate with Seven when she felt so much doubt. She decided to continue to use work as an excuse until she knew more. She'd never been very good at being fake. So pretending that nothing was wrong when something was eating her up inside was not going to be easy. She didn't know what she would tell Seven. She knew he'd probably get suspicious and start to question her if they didn't see each other as often as usual. When her stomach rumbled she realized that she hadn't eaten at lunch and would need to get some food. She made a quick stop to pick up something to eat then she headed home to put together the information Walter needed so she could put the pieces of her love life back together. What hurt the most was realizing that she was just now figuring out *exactly* who the man was she'd given her heart to.

